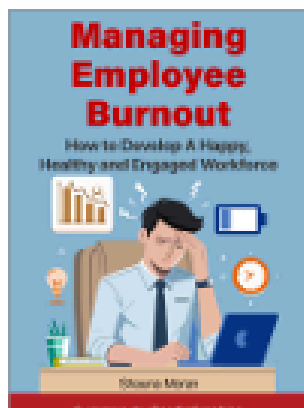




MANAGING EMPLOYEE BURNOUT

How to Develop A Happy, Healthy and Engaged Workforce

Shauna Moran



The Big “So What”

In today's fast-paced world, burnout is becoming increasingly common. This book provides practical, evidence-based strategies to address burnout in the modern workplace. It helps you to prevent personal burnout, and create a supportive work environment that boosts productivity, lowers turnover, and improves employee engagement.



Introduction: What is Burnout?



Definition: According to the World Health Organization (WHO), burnout is a syndrome that occurs when chronic workplace stress is not managed effectively.

- Unlike normal fatigue, burnout causes persistent exhaustion that doesn't go away even with breaks or vacations. It often leads to detachment from work and negative thoughts about work.



Burnout is a common challenge at work. A 2021 Deloitte survey found that 77% of workers have experienced burnout at their current jobs.

- The COVID-19 pandemic worsened burnout due to the sudden shift to remote work, lack of personal outlets, and increased stress and loneliness. Remote workers are more susceptible to burnout because they:
 - (i) Struggle to disconnect from work;
 - (ii) Often lack healthy boundaries; and

KEY QUOTES

“To truly reduce burnout in our teams once and for all, we need to be willing to be uncomfortable and take ownership as an organization and as leaders.”

“True diversity in our workplaces and our teams means that we understand different needs, environments and situations.”

“This book, the stories and research I share, will help you understand the different types of burnout that we experience in our working worlds and how the root causes of burnout can themselves have various root causes.”

(iii) Feel more isolated due to a lack of face-to-face interactions and social activities.

- Burnout has significant financial and emotional costs. A Harvard Business Review article estimates that employee burnout leads to annual healthcare costs of \$125-\$190 billion in the U.S. and 120,000 stress-related deaths. Burnout affects the whole organization, leading to higher employee turnover, reduced productivity, and increased healthcare costs.



While burnout is experienced by individuals, it is actually a systemic problem that requires a multilayered solution. This summary explores:

- The causes and stages of burnout; and
- Strategies to address burnout at the individual, leadership, and organizational levels.

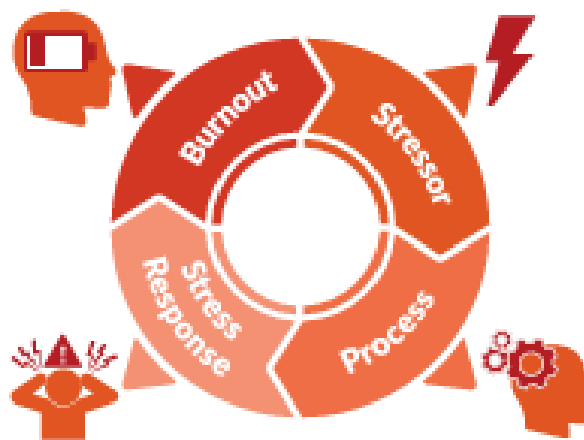


Understanding Burnout



The stress cycle explains how we cope with stress, and how burnout develops in high-stress environments.

- Stress is triggered by stressors, which make us feel like we're missing something essential for survival, physically or emotionally. Some common workplace stressors include critical emails from clients or negative performance reviews.



- The brain processes the stressors to decide if they are threats. We interpret and respond to events differently, based on our personal experiences and psychological makeup.
- If a stressor is perceived as a threat, the body initiates a stress response, with the fight-or-flight reaction at the core. The fight-or-flight response is controlled by the sympathetic nervous system. It leads to increased heart rate, dilated pupils, and heightened senses, preparing us to confront or escape the perceived threats.

KEY QUOTES

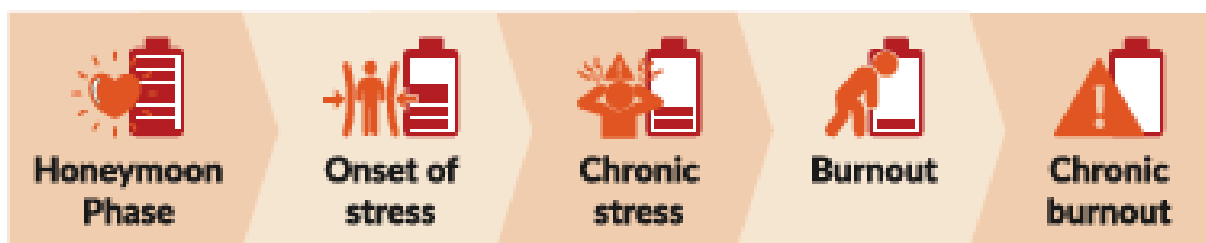
"Now more than ever, it's vital for organizations to look at the impact burnout has on their leaders and to paint the full picture of the true cost of burnout."

"Burnout rarely has just one cause. It's often a combination of many issues stemming from a lack of ownership of oneself, ineffective team processes and cultures, or even a lack of leadership."

"Everyone interprets life differently, through a lens of their perceptions created by their reality. Therefore, we're all going to have different 'threats' or 'triggers'."

- Prolonged activation of the fight-or-flight response can lead to burnout.
- You can break the cycle above by activating the parasympathetic nervous system, which promotes rest, relaxation and recovery to mitigate stress. This can be achieved through deep breathing, walking in nature, meditating, a loving hug, etc.

»» There are many opportunities to stop the stress cycle since burnout doesn't happen overnight. It develops gradually over 5 stages:



- Honeymoon phase: You start off on a new job/task feeling energetic, productive, and motivated. You might volunteer for extra tasks but risk overworking and neglecting self-care.
- Onset of stress: Stress begins to build up, and cracks appear. You start to skip meals, work late, and have less time for personal activities. You might experience headaches, difficulty focusing, and some anxiety.
- Chronic stress: Stress symptoms worsen, leading to a decline in job performance and cognitive abilities. You feel guilt or shame, and get stuck in a cycle of procrastination and overworking. You miss deadlines and feel overwhelmed even by routine tasks.
- Burnout sets in if stress is not managed. Productivity drops, and you may dread work and fall sick easily. You are likely to feel strong emotional physical responses like hopelessness, despair, headaches, digestive problems, and sleep issues.
- Habitual burnout: You feel totally burnt out, and are constantly disengaged, fatigued, and resigned in all aspects of your life.

KEY QUOTES

"You are the gatekeeper for your wellbeing and mental health."

"Life is too short to be unhappy in a career that's killing your soul. Your potential, strengths and abilities are too precious to not be nurtured fully in the ways you need them to."



Addressing Burnout as an Individual



Know the Signs of Burnout and Strategies for Recovery



Before we can address burnout, we must first recognize its signs.

- Burnout can manifest as:
 - (i) Sudden dislike for work you previously enjoyed;
 - (ii) Lower engagement and productivity; and/or
 - (iii) Persistent negative thoughts about work and colleagues.
- Ask these questions:
 - (i) Have you become more cynical, disconnected, or resentful towards your job? Do you feel more irritable or impatient towards colleagues or customers?
 - (ii) Are you overreacting emotionally to work situations that you used to handle calmly?
 - (iii) Do you struggle to switch off from work? Do you feel too tired to be productive?
 - (iv) Are you experiencing unexplained physical issues like headaches, stomach problems, or changes in sleep patterns?
 - (v) Are you using food, drugs, or alcohol to cope with job stress?



Burnout recovery varies among individuals, and can take months or years. Some strategies for recovery include:

- Becoming aware of your stress triggers and levels, so you can manage your responses deliberately.
- Getting emotional support from friends, family, and colleagues.
- Making healthy lifestyle adjustments like sleep, diet, exercise, and engaging in joyful or fulfilling activities.

KEY QUOTES

"To build self-awareness, we must strengthen our conscious connection to all three brain regions: our thoughts, emotions, and gut instincts."

"It's not about how much time you have, but rather how you can bring awareness to spend some time on yourself before you spend time with the outside world."

- Setting clear boundaries during recovery, e.g. saying no to social invitations or extra responsibilities to protect your energy and focus.



Build Self-Awareness and Emotional Intelligence



Studies show that employees with emotional intelligence (EI) perform better at work and are less likely to experience burnout. Self awareness and EI are especially crucial for remote workers, who must manage their own schedules and environments, and cope with team dynamics in a virtual setting.



Strengthen your ability to manage your needs, emotions, and interactions with others.

- Throughout the day, regularly assess your physical-emotional state, identify what you need to feel at your best, and adjust your plans and activities accordingly.
- Equip yourself with strategies for managing negative emotions.
 - (i) Pick 3 key emotions (e.g. anger, fear, sadness) and brainstorm 5 ways to manage each.
 - (ii) You can shift your mood by changing your posture (e.g. smile, relax your posture, or roll your shoulders), do deep breathing or take short breaks.
- Get feedback from trusted colleagues on how your emotions affect them. Use these insights to adjust your emotional responses and improve interactions.



Improve Your Remote Work Practices



One of the key advantage of remote work is its flexibility. Use that to design your schedule based on when/how you work best.

- Organizations should let people plan their work according to their needs and body rhythms, instead of insisting on standard 9-5 hours. For example, a working mom might prefer to spend the mornings with her children and work later in the day. People also have different peak productivity times.

KEY QUOTES

"Remote working is not for everyone, and it takes a particular skill set and abilities to work independently at home."

"By being aware of your feelings, you have the power to change your emotional reactions to situations."

"The more strategies you have at your disposal, the more emotionally agile you will become."

"How might the employees' experience in your organization change if all your people had more autonomy to create their own schedules?"

★  Prioritize your tasks by urgency and importance. Then, focus on the most important tasks that contribute the most to your goals.

 Set aside time for deep work. Cal Newport describes deep work as focusing 100% on a complex task, without distractions. This enables you to learn faster and produce better results. By contrast, shallow work, involves tasks that don't need much concentration, such as responding to emails.

- Individual level: If you're more focused and energetic in the mornings, then dedicate mornings for deep work and schedule meetings later in the day.
- Team level: Dedicate time for team brainstorming, problem-solving, and planning.

 Incorporate wellness into your routine.

- Research shows that productivity drops significantly after 50 hours of work per week. Take frequent, high-quality breaks to improve productivity and prevent burnout. Make sure you include activities that refresh and de-stress you.

→  Establish healthy boundaries to improve productivity and to switch off from work without guilt.

- Wellness is different for everyone, so identify the boundaries that you need. These could include physical boundaries (e.g. a designated workspace), or mental-emotional boundaries (e.g. setting pre-determined work hours and having uninterrupted time for focused work).
- Communicate and enforce these boundaries with colleagues. Create a safe space where team members can discuss boundary concerns openly.

 Establish a routine for the start and end of each workday.

- Create a start-up routine to energize yourself before work, e.g. meditate, exercise for 5 minutes, or enjoy a cup of coffee.
- Establish a wind-down routine to relax and switch off from work, e.g. faking a commute, writing down your end-of-the-day thoughts, or watching your favorite program.

KEY QUOTES

"How you manage and prioritize your tasks can be the difference between feeling overwhelmed...and being effective at getting your work done."

"There's a difference between working remotely and being genuinely effective at remote working."

"The key to successful remote working in any team and for any individual is understanding how to leverage the flexibility of remote working."

"If nobody considers the fundamental right to disconnect from work, nobody has the opportunity to disconnect."

"Defining and setting your boundaries provides you with a set of rules to operate by and tells others how you'd like to be treated."

KEY QUOTES

- Reflect on your work habits and routine to keep refining them. Consider what went well, what didn't go well, and what you should do differently. Keep what works, and adjust what doesn't.



Addressing Burnout as an Organization



Burnout is a systemic issue that requires organizational changes and support. It cannot be resolved at an individual or talent management level alone.

- To understand the full impact of burnout, companies should measure its effects on absenteeism, stress-leave, turnover rates, and productivity issues.



Address Key Reasons for Burnout

A Gallup survey identified 5 key reasons for burnout at work.



Unfair treatment: Discrimination, harassment, and bullying contribute to burnout. Employees are 2.3x more likely to experience burnout if they feel unfairly treated at work.

- Establish clear policies against unfair treatment such as offensive comments, unfair demotions, or gender bias. Use FAQs and examples to ensure employees understand these policies and the support available.
- Address proximity bias, which occurs when employees in the office are seen as more effective/committed than remote workers. Educate leaders and encourage them to work remotely to understand team members' work conditions. Ensure remote workers receive the same information and perks as in-office employees.



Excessive workload leads to poorer performance, decreased confidence, and more stress.

- Distribute work fairly and set limits on temporary surges in work.
- Focus on output or results, not input or time spent working.

"The actions of organizations have a greater impact on the reduction and prevention of burnout than any one individual can make on their own."

"The true cost of burnout should be presented in ways that speak both to the heart and the head."

"Consider a high-performing culture that promotes and only recognizes achievement and results."

- Create a safe environment where employees can discuss workloads without fear of negative consequences.



Role ambiguity: Without clear roles and responsibilities, employees can feel confused, stressed, and overworked.

- Do a comprehensive onboarding for new hires, with a complete digital guide and resources. Set clear expectations, including: their responsibilities, what success in the first 30 days looks like, and how they contribute to company goals.
- Facilitate virtual introductions with other team members, and pair new hires with experienced employees for a few months.
- Hold regular 1-1 meetings to clarify roles/expectations in face of changes in the work environment.



Lack of managerial support: When leaders are overloaded, they can't effectively support or connect with their team members.

- Limit the number of direct reports to a manageable number (ideally less than 7).
- Reduce non-essential tasks to free up leaders' time for coaching and supporting their teams.
- Train leaders on critical skills like emotional intelligence, active listening, and coaching.



Too many unrealistic deadlines can create a snowball effect, where a delay on 1 project affects all other projects.

- Set achievable goals and timelines together with employees. Consider if other tasks should be re-prioritized or delegated.



Develop a Healthy Work Culture



Remote work is becoming increasingly prevalent. To attract and retain top talent, you need a healthy work culture.

- Many employees prefer remote work for flexibility and global opportunities. A Flexjobs survey found that 65% of employees prefer remote work, and 58% would look for new jobs if they're required to return to the office.

KEY QUOTES

"It is ambiguity that leads to confusion, self-doubt and overworking in remote teams."

"Employee burnout is preventable, not inevitable, because burnout isn't a personal failing, it's often a sign that an employee isn't receiving adequate support."

"If everything is urgent, then nothing is urgent."

"In a candidate-driven market, having a good reputation as an employer has become key to attracting great new employees."

- Remote work also gives companies access to a broader talent pool. However, to attract and retain top talent, you need a strong culture and reputation, and to hire and manage remote workers effectively. High stress and burnout can lead to high turnover and loss of talent.



Hire remote workers with emotional intelligence (EQ) and self-management skills, then equip them with the skills and space to succeed.

- Remote workers need self-awareness and self-management skills to manage their schedules and interactions effectively. Look for EQ, adaptability, and independence during your hiring process. Ask questions like: "Describe a situation where you admitted to being wrong and how you handled it" or "How do you maintain relationships remotely?"



To build a healthy work environment:

- Develop a purpose-driven work culture:
 - (i) Help employees understand the purpose behind their work, to improve engagement and reduce the risks that they will burnout or quit.
 - (ii) Involve employees in CSR activities aligned with their values and the organization's mission.
- Balance between excellence and employee wellbeing:
 - (i) Respect employees' right to disconnect, and encourage them to take breaks and vacations after periods of intense work.
 - (ii) Implement policies like meeting-free days or communication-free afternoons.
- Create flexible work arrangements: Allow employees to choose their work hours and location. Consider a 4-day workweek, which has been found to reduce stress and improve work-life balance.
- Adopt a growth mindset: Continuously improve company culture by collecting employee feedback and addressing unmet needs to keep them happy and healthy.

KEY QUOTES

"Your culture will eat any strategy for breakfast"
—Peter Drucker

"All the boundary building in the world won't help your team members all that much if your organization doesn't have a culture and policies that support their efforts."

"The pay cheque is essential, but the purpose is critical."

"Often, it's not about what organizations do but how they do it....Ebbs and flows are a natural cycle on this planet...so why do some organizations expect their teams to perform at 100 per cent all day, every day?"

"Changing culture requires changing mindset."



Optimize Processes for Remote Teams



Remote workers are often so busy with back-to-back meetings, messages, and "Zoom fatigue" that they have no time/energy for creative work or "me-time". Adopt remote-first processes:

- Design processes (e.g. project management, communication, and performance evaluation processes) for remote teams, then adapt them for in-office settings.



Clear communication is essential for trust and engagement, especially for distributed teams.

- Synchronous communication occurs in real time, such as video calls or face-to-face meetings.
 - (i) Hold such meetings only if necessary. Set clear objectives and expected outcomes for each meeting, keep them short, and include only essential participants.
 - (ii) Start and end meetings on time, and avoid scheduling meetings back-to-back.
- Asynchronous communication involves delayed responses, such as email or instant messaging tools. This allows for more thoughtful responses, and it's generally more viable for distributed teams with members from different time zones.
 - (i) Set clear communication guidelines for the use of Slack, email, or other tools. Generally, it's better to over-communicate by providing all details upfront—including task urgency, expected response times, required actions, and relevant materials—so no clarifications will be required.
 - (ii) Be mindful of tone, time zones, and off-hours. Team members should use "Do Not Disturb" statuses as needed.
 - (iii) For complex discussions, consider a short call/meeting, then record and share the details to avoid information being lost in message chains.
- Tailor your mix of synchronous and asynchronous communication to suit your team's needs.
 - (i) Co-create shared practices with team members for ownership and sustainability.

KEY QUOTES

"The difference between companies that succeed at their remote team processes and those that don't lies in their openness and ability to create new processes based around how a remote team operates remote-first processes."

"Meetings are fundamental to the success of remote teams, but they need to be of high quality."

"The autonomy that comes with working remotely and primarily alone means we should be tapped into ourselves as individuals to make better decisions that promote our overall wellbeing."

- (ii) Where possible, choose flexible (async) communication over real-time meetings, and written communication over verbal ones.
- (iii) Regularly consider what you should start, stop, or continue doing as a team.



Addressing Burnout as a Leader

Leadership impacts 70% of employee engagement. It's crucial to equip leaders with the right skills and resources to manage people effectively.



Build Trust and Psychological Safety

Leaders must know the differences in managing remote teams and office-based teams.

- An office setting offers lots of opportunities for casual interactions, like a spontaneous chat with a colleague in the office pantry. These help to build personal connections between team members beyond their work roles. Such opportunities are missing in a remote setting, so leaders should intentionally create virtual coffee chats or other bonding opportunities.
- It's easier for leaders to notice signs of stress and burnout in the office, where they can observe team members' mood shifts and body language.
 - (i) In remote settings, use video calls to observe non-verbal cues like posture, eye bags, or fidgeting—which are potential signs of stress or overwhelm.
 - (ii) Ask about their wellbeing if you notice any red flags. Don't wait for the “right time” to raise issues.



Build psychological safety: Create an environment where people feel safe to discuss challenges and share opinions openly.

KEY QUOTES

“We can better build empathy towards our colleagues by finding common ground and interests outside of just working together as a team.”

“As a remote leader, you must...go the extra mile in terms of proactive communication and acknowledgement.”

“Trust is an aspect of leadership that we often overlook. We can't quantify it, but it accelerates growth in all that we do, both in business and in our personal lives.”

KEY QUOTES

- Engage everyone: During meetings, invite each person to speak through voice or chat. Quieter members can share their thoughts through images or GIFs.
- Listen actively: Give your full attention during discussions. Turn off notifications and close other tabs.
- Invite participation by asking open-ended questions like, "What questions do you have right now?" instead of close-ended questions like "Do you have any questions?" Pause to give time for responses.
- Discuss expectations openly to build trust, understanding, and cooperation. Define working methods, problem-solving strategies, success metrics or outcomes. Accommodate different communication preferences, e.g. some people prefer to text, while others prefer a brief chat before discussing work.
- Hold regular 1-1 meetings to support/coach team members on task prioritization and performance management, and to create a safe space to address misunderstandings or conflicts. Aim for at least 45-minute sessions every 2 weeks.

"We...want to hold space and to create safety for the people we work with to speak up when they need to."



Provide Emotional Support for Team Members



Leaders can reduce emotional exhaustion by providing clear roles, predictable work conditions, and meaningful tasks.

- Role clarity: Ensure team members know what to do, especially during times of change. People are less prone to burnout when they're clear on their responsibilities.
- Predictability: Guide team members through changes.
 - (i) Use 1-1 conversations to explain why changes are necessary and beneficial, and to address questions or concerns. Keep the communication lines open with regular updates and discussions.
 - (ii) Share personal experiences to build trust and encourage open discussion.
- Meaningful work: Employees are more engaged and less likely to burnout when they know that their work matters.

"A problem shared is indeed a problem halved. If we can reduce the outcast beliefs that we hold about ourselves when we're going through a challenging time as a professional, we have started to solve the problem."

- (i) Clearly define tasks, outcomes, and their significance.
- (ii) Set realistic deadlines, and re-prioritize existing tasks if required. Agree on how to communicate progress and address problems. Clarify how much autonomy each person has to make decisions.
- (iii) Create a team culture of recognition. Regularly celebrate efforts and achievements via praises, notes, or shout-outs.



Organizations should provide support, systems, resources, and recognition, to help leaders perform such emotional-support roles more more effectively.

- Leaders can also build support networks by developing connections between team members, or nurturing new relationships to enhance collaboration.



Guide Teams Through Effective Coaching



Coaching helps team members to identify professional issues and solve problems. Effective coaching begins with leaders' understanding of themselves, including their own perceptions, beliefs, and biases.

- Use personality assessments to help leaders deepen their self-awareness. Then, encourage leaders to set specific goals for leadership development based on their personality test results.



Here are several tips for effective coaching:

- Don't fix team members' problems for them. Empower problem-solving by helping them to reflect on the problem, explore options, and arrive at their own solutions.
- When a team member approaches you with a problem, seek permission to coach them. For example, say, "I'd like to try some coaching with you to explore possible solutions. Are you open to that?"
- Engage fully: Set up a video call with cameras on, and listen fully for both verbal and non-verbal cues.
- Use questions to guide your team member:

KEY QUOTES

"If organizations fail to support their leaders in emotional labour it can lead to stress, depersonalization and other emotional outcomes like lower job satisfaction."

"What's...important is that companies...offer leaders the support that they need when dealing with more emotionally exhausting issues and help them be recognized for this type of work, rather than just the output of their work."

"Too often, leaders are trying to support and coach their team members to help them reach their full potential without necessarily doing that for themselves first."

"Instead of providing fixes, coaching helps individuals reflect on their own ideas and solutions and reality-test them out loud in a supportive environment."

"As a leader, you'll want to actively listen to what's being said, and what's been communicated through the unspoken-body language, eye contact, facial expressions and posture."

- (i) Clarify the problem by asking questions like, “What specific tasks or factors are making you feel this way?” Guide them to identify the root causes, by thinking back on when/why the problem first started.
- (ii) Encourage ownership: After identifying the problem, ask them to suggest the next steps. For instance, “Based on our discussion, what do you think is the most important next step and why?”
- (iii) End the session by inviting them to summarize the discussion and action steps. Discuss any support they might need, and set a follow-up date to check on their progress.



Role-Model Healthy Behaviors



Leaders' actions set the standard for team members. One of the best ways to address burnout is for leaders to role-model the healthy behaviors they want to see in their team.

- Don't forget to address your wellbeing as a leader. Ask yourself: How do I recognize burnout symptoms in myself? What actions can I take to address such symptoms? What support is available to me? How can I set a positive example for wellbeing at work?



Here are several ways to role-model healthy practices:

- Taking regular breaks throughout the workday, and disconnect fully from work during off-hours. Log off from all work technology to show it's ok to be unreachable.
- Share wellbeing practices and habits that you find useful while working remotely.
- Offer glimpses into your life and values outside of work.
- Don't be afraid to take breaks or vacations. Demonstrate how to handover important projects and meetings in advance, and prepare team members to handle the work in your absence.

KEY QUOTES

"As a coaching leader, it's your responsibility to be open to all possibilities in terms of root causes and to rule nothing out."

"To lead by example means to guide others through your behavior instead of your words."

"To create a healthy team, you need to feel healthy yourself."

"Leaders can't pour from an empty cup—meaning if they are trying to support their team without supporting themselves, they risk burnout."



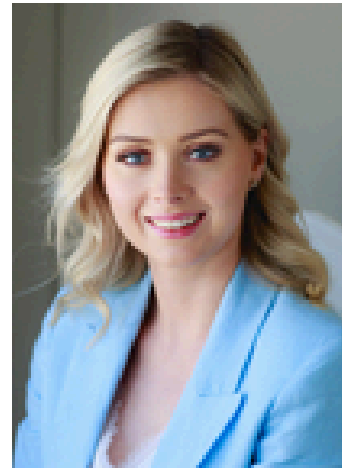
Other Details in the Book to Look out For

Remember: organizations flourish when employees thrive. This book includes many examples, case studies, detailed tips and best practices for managing burnout, especially for remote workers. It covers details for various interventions at individual, organizational, and leadership levels. For more details, please visit www.shaunamoran.com.



About the Author

Shauna Moran is an author and leadership coach who specializes in preventing burnout and improving organizational health. She founded Operate Remote, a consultancy firm that develops remote and hybrid work strategies for companies. Focusing on team performance and employee well-being, Shauna offers practical insights for leaders to foster supportive work environments.



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KEY QUOTES

"Never underestimate the power of making small incremental changes for yourself, your team or your wider organization towards the prevention and management of burnout."